

Senate confirms ‘dual hat’ spy chief

Rudd will helm NSA and Cybercom after a year of leadership limbo

BY ELLEN NAKASHIMA AND NOAH ROBERTSON

Gen. Joshua M. Rudd was confirmed Tuesday as the next head of the National Security Agency and U.S. Cyber Command, ending nearly one year of leadership limbo at the nation’s largest spy agency and the military’s offensive cyber organization.

Rudd, a former Delta Force commander, was confirmed by the Senate in a 71-29 vote. The confirmation elevates him to a four-star general, and he is expected to take up his position soon.

Rudd will assume command over an intelligence agency shaken by the abrupt firing of its director, Gen. Timothy Haugh, and Deputy Director Wendy Noble by President Donald Trump in April. The president’s move drew sharp bipartisan rebukes as an unjustified political move engineered by the far-right activist Laura Loomer.

Rudd will also serve in a “dual hat” role as head of U.S. Cyber Command, which conducts offensive and defensive cyber operations.

Cybercom operators took actions such as temporary power cuts to help enable the Jan. 3 military raid that resulted in the capture of Venezuelan strongman Nicolás Maduro and, along with Space Command, helped disrupt communications and sensor networks in the first hours of the ongoing U.S.-Israeli military operation against Iran.

For the past year and a half, Rudd has served as deputy head of U.S. Indo-Pacific Command, which is the largest of the six combatant commands by geography and is largely focused on countering the Chinese military’s aggressive push for regional dominance.

“General Rudd is a war hero with a lifetime of service to our nation,” said Sen. Tom Cotton

SEE RUDD ON A9



JOEL ANGEL JUAREZ/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Army recruit Justin Matous, 18, hugs his aunt Dorothy Rodriguez at his going-away party in Lometa, Texas, on Saturday.

LOMETA, TEXAS — The United States was not yet at war when Emm Matous barely agreed to host this going-away party for her son.

Since serving in Iraq, even small crowds bothered her, which was why she lived on a middle-of-nowhere ranch with a chore list that included shooting rattlesnakes. The combat veteran, 41, also dreaded crying in front of anyone, especially her baby boy, who was still her baby boy, despite being 18 years old, 6-foot-5, and newly married.

Emm figured, though, she could hold it together for Justin the day before he left for basic training. “At least he’s joining up

A son leaves. A mother still fights.

As Justin Matous joins the Army, Emm recovers from her time serving in Iraq

BY DANIELLE PAQUETTE

at peacetime,” she’d thought. But now American bombs were exploding across Iran, and the president she’d voted for was refusing to rule out troops on the ground, and a guest was stepping through her black double doors with a case of Mountain Dew.

He greeted Justin with the question that agonized her. “You ready?”

Everyone seemed to have an opinion on President Donald Trump thrusting the country into another conflict without a clear end. It’s righteous. It’s wrong. We trust him. He betrayed us. The commentary was nonstop, overwhelming, all over her Facebook

SEE VETERANS ON A6

Claim: Ex-DOGE worker said he took private data

BY MERYL KORNFIELD, ELIZABETH DWOSKIN AND LISA REIN

The Social Security Administration’s internal watchdog is investigating a complaint that alleges a former U.S. DOGE Service employee claimed he had access to two highly sensitive agency databases and planned to share the information with his private

employer — a claim that, if true, would constitute an unprecedented breach of security protocols at an agency that serves more than 70 million Americans.

The agency’s inspector general is investigating the disclosure and has alerted members of Congress of its existence, according to a letter by the acting inspector general to top members of four congressional committees re-

viewed by The Washington Post and two people familiar with the process, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe sensitive deliberations. The inspector general’s office has also shared the disclosure with the Government Accountability Office, which has been conducting its own audit of DOGE’s access to data, according to one of the people. The Post has reviewed the

complaint and spoken with the whistleblower, who issued the complaint anonymously for fear of retaliation.

According to the disclosure, the former DOGE software engineer, who worked at the Social Security Administration last year before starting a job at a government contractor in October, allegedly told several co-workers

SEE WHISTLEBLOWER ON A4

Oil jolt triggers GOP anxiety

POLITICAL PERIL IN SEESAWING PRICES

Hegseth says Iran’s mullahs are ‘desperate’

BY HANNAH KNOWLES

President Donald Trump was eager to point to gas prices in his State of the Union speech last month as he touted his administration’s progress on the economy.

“Gasoline, which reached a peak of over \$6 a gallon in some states under my predecessor — it was, quite honestly, a disaster — is now below \$2.30 a gallon in most states,” Trump boasted minutes into his nearly-two-hour address, framing his party’s message heading into the midterms.

Two weeks later, his war with Iran threatens to undermine that pitch.

Oil prices Monday spiked to levels not seen since Russia invaded Ukraine in 2022, while prices at the pump jumped nearly 50 cents higher than a week ago. The price per barrel jumped to almost \$120 at one point Monday before dropping to under \$90 by the end of the day as Trump suggested the war with Iran could end soon. But the roller coaster still left some in his party anxious about the political and economic fallout, particularly as Iran has vowed to continue retaliatory strikes.

At a briefing Tuesday, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said Iran’s mullahs are “desperate and scrambling” and it would be “our most intense day of strikes inside Iran.”

Gen. Dan Caine, the Joint Chiefs of Staff chairman, said the U.S. military would “look at the range of options” if tasked with escorting tankers through the Strait of Hormuz, which is effectively closed because of the conflict, ratcheting up global energy

SEE IRAN ON A2

U.S. toll: Pentagon says about 140 troops wounded, 8 severely. **A11**

Democrats launch probe into Trump library funds

BY DAN DIAMOND AND AARON SCHAFER

Congressional Democrats are opening a probe into millions of dollars private companies pledged to President Donald Trump’s planned presidential library, asking what happened to the money after the original fund was dissolved last year.

Sens. Elizabeth Warren (Massachusetts) and Richard Blumenthal (Connecticut) and Rep. Melanie Stansbury (New Mexico) wrote Monday to the leaders of ABC, Meta, Paramount and X, requesting information about the terms of their agreements and the status of the funds they pledged to hand over to the president’s representatives. The letters were shared with The Washington Post.

The four companies each committed millions of dollars to the

SEE TRUMP ON A4

Soaking up the sun



MAXINE WALLACE/THE WASHINGTON POST

People enjoy a balmy Tuesday at Gravelly Point Park in Arlington, where the temperature reached 81 degrees, well above the average for the region. Today, the Capital Weather Gang forecasts highs in the mid- to upper 70s. **Weather, B18**

Congress shrinks as it cedes power to Trump

The president was able to start a war and levy sweeping tariffs

BY LIZ GOODWIN

Early in March, senators gathered to take a vote meant to remind President Donald Trump of Congress’s power.

Just a few days before, the president had launched a war against Iran without seeking legislative approval. Two senators pushed forward a resolution that would have halted the fighting until Congress officially authorized military action — its prerogative under a 1973 law passed near the end of the Vietnam War.

On his way into the Senate chamber, Sen. Rand Paul, a Republican and libertarian from

Kentucky, said founder James Madison once wrote that each branch of government’s ambition would counteract that of the others.

“But I think Madison never imagined or envisioned a Congress with no ambition,” Paul said. “This is a Congress without ambition. This is a Congress without really a belief structure in defending legislative prerogative. They just are a rubber stamp for whatever a president tells them to do.”

Paul walked onto the Senate floor and cast the lone GOP vote for the measure, which failed.

The vote was merely the latest capitulation of a GOP-controlled Congress that has subordinated itself to the executive branch headed by Trump. While lawmakers once jealously guarded their constitutionally endowed power over spending, trade and war —

SEE CONGRESS ON A18

Trump Rules: This story is part of a series that examines how the president and his aides are rewriting the rules of power in Washington.

IN THE NEWS

‘Strategic failure’ Senate Democrats argue in a new report that the Trump administration’s diplomatic and trade policies are weakening America’s advantage over China. **A12**

Truckers and farmers worry If the war keeps up for much longer, diesel could soon test its all-time high of \$5.82, set in June 2022. **A11**

THE NATION A judge also disqualified the lawyers picked to replace Alina Habba as U.S. attorney. **A8**
How to ditch “forever chemicals,” which build up in our bodies, without getting cold or wet. **A8**

THE WORLD Canadian police are seeking two men suspected of firing a gun at a U.S. Consulate. **A12**
The president urged Latin American leaders to use their militaries against drug cartels. **A12**

THE ECONOMY It’s tax season, and about a third of the country will owe money to the government. The worst possible move is to do nothing. **A13**
The stock market held steadier as Wall Street waited for the next signal on when the war with Iran may end. **A13**

STYLE In Netflix’s “Vladimir” and HBO’s “Rooster,” college professors struggle with the sexual politics of a culture shifting beneath their feet. **B1**
SPORTS The U.S. and Canada are set to clash again in the hockey rink, this time at the Paralympics. **B7**

THE REGION An appearance of the red-flanked bluetail, a bird rarely seen in the U.S., sends people flocking to Virginia. **B13**
FOOD Green drinks for St. Patrick’s Day are so cliché. Here’s why you should make one anyway. **E1**

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